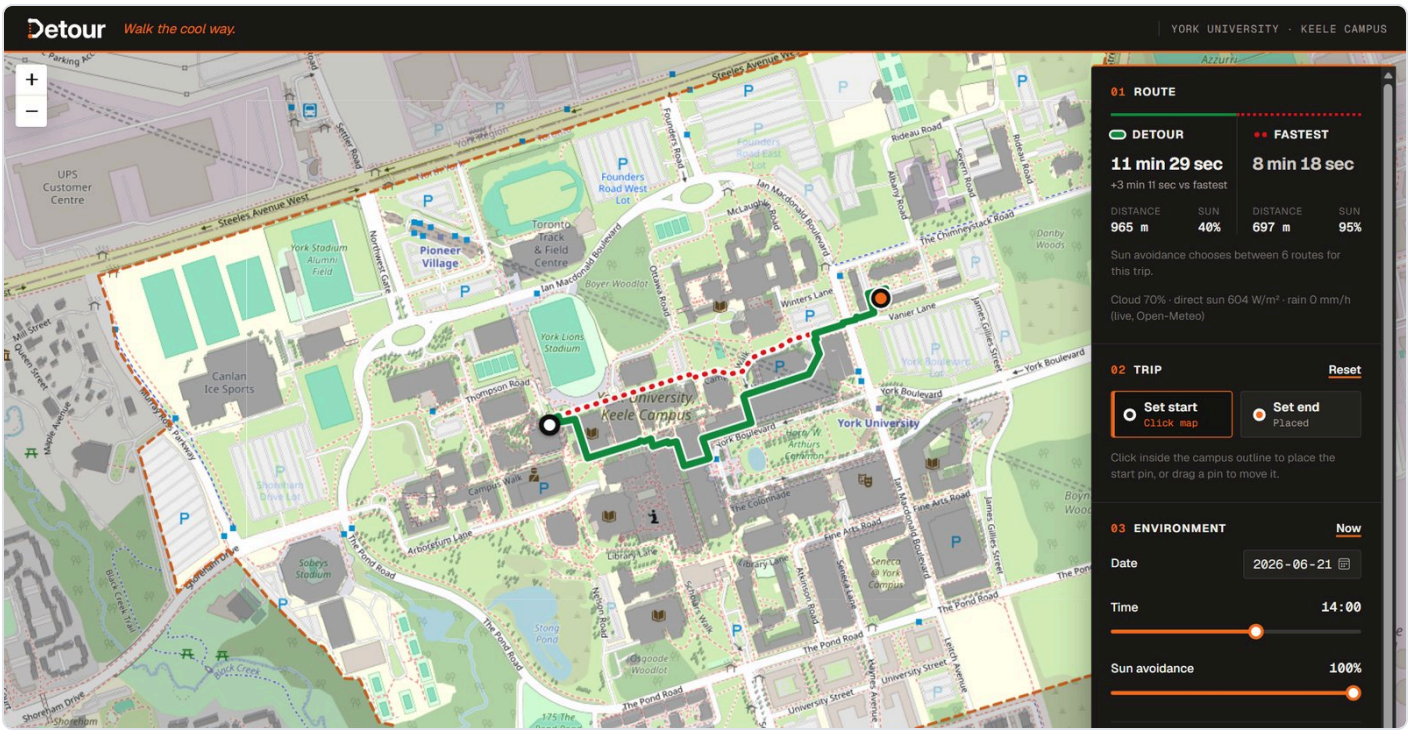
Detour

Walk the cool way.

Technical Study Guide

Heat-aware walking navigation for York University's Keele Campus: how the final code works, from the React map to the routing mathematics.

1,804	5,172	737 + 1,181	9
walkway intersections (graph vertices)	directed walkway edges	buildings + trees that cast shadows	time/shade route options on the demo trip



The real app on 21 June 2026 at 14:00, with live weather and shadows shown. Green = Detour route (100 % sun avoidance: 40 % sun for 3 min 11 s more), red dots = fastest route (95 % sun), orange dashes = campus boundary.

Written from the final code on `main` (18 Oct 2026). Every number in this guide was produced by running the actual code, unless marked otherwise. Frontend: Next.js 16.4.2, React 19.3, Leaflet 1.9 / react-leaflet 5. Backend: Python 3.14, FastAPI 0.143, OSMnx 2.1, Shapely 2.2, pvlib 0.16.

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How to use this guide

- **Everyone** should know chapters 1, 3, 7 (the big picture of the algorithm), 14 and 17.
- **Frontend person:** chapters 2–4. **Graph person:** 6–7. **Math person:** 8–10. **Backend person:** 5, 11–13.
- Chapter 18 is a glossary: look up any word you are not sure about.
- Green boxes are key facts, orange boxes are traps judges like to probe, yellow boxes are likely judge questions.

THE THREE UNIT TRAPS

- **Sun avoidance** is 0–100 in the UI *and* in the URL (`sun_avoidance=50`); the backend divides by 100 and works with 0.5.
- **Sun %** (`sun_percent`) is already a percentage when it leaves the backend (e.g. `95.1`), not a fraction.
- **Cloud cover** is a fraction 0–1 in the API (`0.7`) and the UI multiplies it by 100 to show "Cloud 70 %".

THE COORDINATE TRAP

The frontend and Leaflet use `[latitude, longitude]` . GeoJSON uses `[longitude, latitude]` . The backend computes in metres (UTM zone 17N: x = east, y = north). See §4.4.

1 Project overview

Detour finds walking routes across York University's Keele Campus that keep you out of the direct sun (and, optionally, out of the rain), and shows how much extra walking that costs.

1.1 The problem

Normal navigation apps minimise time or distance. On a hot day, the fastest route can be in full sun while a route that is only a minute longer runs along the shady side of buildings and trees. Detour answers: "*How much sun can I avoid, and what does it cost me in time?*"

1.2 What the user does

1. Clicks the map to place a **start** pin and an **end** pin (only inside the campus outline).
2. Chooses a **date** and **time** (defaults to "now" in Toronto) and a **sun avoidance** level from 0 % to 100 %.
3. Optionally turns on **Avoid rain** and **Show shadows**.
4. Sees two routes: the Fastest route (dotted red) and the Detour route (solid green), with time, distance and sun % for each, plus the live weather used.

1.3 Architecture

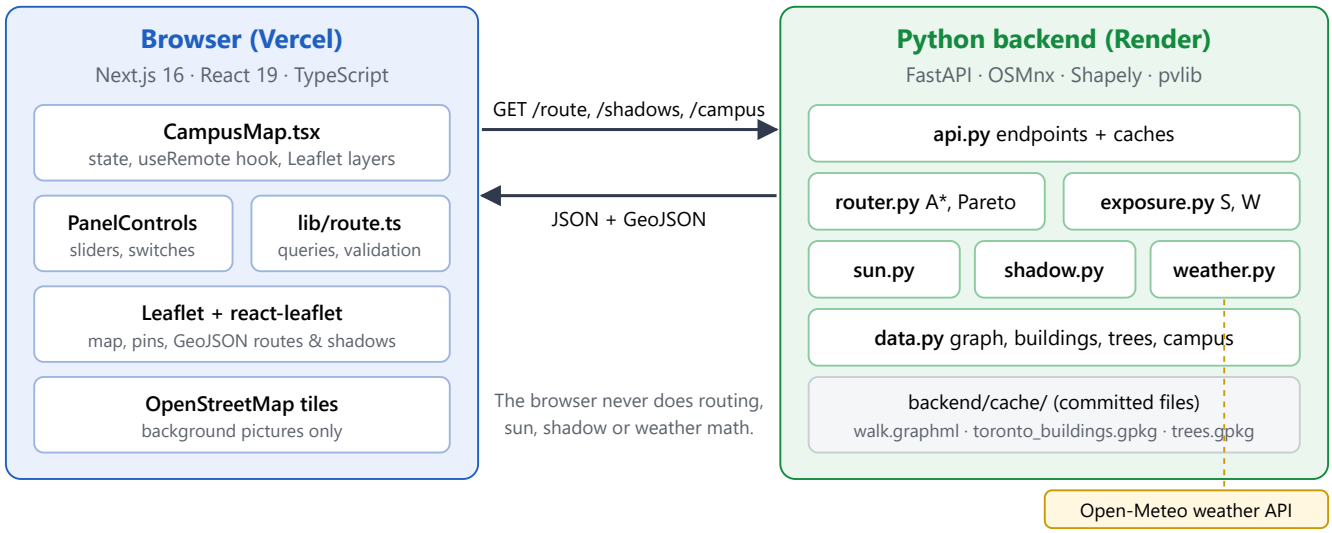


Figure 1. Two separately deployed programs that talk over HTTP. The frontend draws; the backend thinks.

1.4 Technologies

Layer	Technology	What we use it for
UI framework	Next.js 16.4.2 (App Router), React 19.3	Page shell, components, state, fonts, static build
Language	TypeScript 5	Type-checked frontend code; API response types
Map	Leaflet 1.9 + react-leaflet 5	Interactive map, pins, routes, shadow polygons
Styling	Tailwind CSS 4 + `globals.css`	Layout, panel, Leaflet overrides
API server	FastAPI 0.143 + Uvicorn	HTTP endpoints, parameter validation, JSON
Map data	OSMnx 2.1 (OpenStreetMap), City of Toronto 3D Massing 2025	Walk network, campus boundary, trees; building footprints and heights
Geometry	Shapely 2.2, GeoPandas 1.2, pyproj 3.8	Shadow polygons, spatial index, coordinate conversion
Graph	NetworkX 3.7 (data structure) + our own A* / Pareto search	Routing
Astronomy	pvlib 0.16 (NREL Solar Position Algorithm)	Sun elevation and azimuth
Weather	Open-Meteo (free, no API key) via httpx	Direct sunlight, cloud cover, precipitation
Checks	ESLint; `next build` (TypeScript)	Lint and type-checked production build (§13)
Hosting	Vercel (frontend), Render (backend, `render.yaml`)	Deploy on every push to `main`

1.5 Repository map

```
src/
  app/layout.tsx     root HTML, fonts, CSS
  app/page.tsx       header + map region
  app/globals.css    all styling
  components/
    CampusMapLoader.tsx  client-only
    CampusMap.tsx        map + state
    PanelControls.tsx    UI pieces
  lib/route.ts       types, queries
scripts/  setup, dev, venv (.mjs)
```

```
backend/
  api.py       endpoints, caches, snapping
  router.py    A*, Pareto options, pick()
  exposure.py  shade/shelter, S and W
  shadow.py    building + tree shadows
  sun.py       pvlib sun position
  weather.py   Open-Meteo client
  data.py      load OSM + Toronto data
  cache/  data/
```

2 Frontend: Next.js, React, TypeScript

The frontend is one page. Almost everything interesting happens in `CampusMap.tsx`; `lib/route.ts` holds the pure helpers.

2.1 Concepts in one table

Concept	Plain-English meaning	Where in Detour
Next.js	A framework on top of React: file-based pages, a build system, fonts, images, server rendering.	`src/app/`: `layout.tsx`, `page.tsx`
React	A library where the UI is a function of data. You describe what the screen should look like for the current data; React updates the page.	Every `.tsx` component
TypeScript	JavaScript with types. Mistakes like passing a string where a number is expected fail at build time.	`RouteResponse`, `LatLon`, `Scenario` types
Component	A function that returns UI.	`CampusMap`, `Slider`, `Switch`, `RoutePair`
Props	Inputs passed from a parent to a child component (read-only for the child).	`<Slider label="Time" value={minutes} onChange={setMinutes} />`
State	Data a component remembers between renders. Changing it makes React re-render.	date, minutes, pins, toggles (§2.7)
useState	Hook that creates one piece of state and its setter.	`const [date, setDate] = useState(...)`
useEffect	Hook that runs side effects (timers, network) after render, with a cleanup function.	The fetch inside `useRemote`
Custom hook	Your own function that uses hooks, so logic can be reused.	`useRemote()` is used 3 times: route, shadows, campus
Controlled input	An input whose value comes from React state, and whose `onChange` updates that state.	Date input, both sliders, both switches
Re-render	React calls the component function again after state changes and updates only what differs.	Every slider move re-renders `CampusMap`
Event	A user action delivered to a handler function.	Map click, pin `dragend`, slider `onChange`, button `onClick`
SSR	Server-side rendering: HTML is produced before reaching the browser.	The header is prerendered as static HTML; the map is not (next row)
Dynamic import	Load a module only in the browser, later.	`CampusMapLoader` loads Leaflet with `ssr: false`

2.2 `layout.tsx` and `page.tsx`

`layout.tsx` is the root of every page. It sets the page title "Detour | Walk the cool way.", the description and icon, loads the Geist fonts with `next/font/google`, and imports `leaflet/dist/leaflet.css` and `globals.css`. It renders `<html><body>{children}</body></html>`.

`page.tsx` is a *server component* (no `"use client"`). It renders the header (wordmark image via `next/image`, slogan, "York University · Keele Campus") and a `<section>` containing `<CampusMapLoader />`. The build output shows the route `/` as `○ (Static)`: prerendered once at build time.

2.3 `CampusMapLoader.tsx`: why the map is loaded dynamically

```
"use client";
const CampusMap = dynamic(() => import("./CampusMap"), {
  ssr: false,
  loading: () => <div aria-label="Loading map" className="campus-map" />,
});
```

WHY SSR: FALSE

Leaflet reads `window` and `document` as soon as it is imported. On the server those do not exist, so importing Leaflet during server rendering would crash. `dynamic(..., {ssr:false})` means: render an empty placeholder on the server, then download and run `CampusMap` only in the browser. In Next.js 16 `ssr:false` is only allowed inside a client component, which is why this tiny wrapper file exists.

2.4 `CampusMap.tsx`: the main component

About 500 lines. It owns all the state, calls the backend through the `useRemote` hook, draws the Leaflet layers and renders the side panel (sections **01 Route**, **02 Trip**, **03 Environment**).

2.5 `PanelControls.tsx`

Presentation-only components; no routing logic.

- **`Slider`**: a controlled `<input type="range">` with a label and a formatted value. Its CSS variable `--fill` = (value − min)/(max − min) × 100 % colours the track.
- **`Switch`**: a controlled checkbox with `role="switch"` (accessible toggle).
- **`RoutePair` / `RouteSummary`**: Detour and Fastest side by side: time (`fmtSpan`: "1 min 19 sec"), distance (`fmtDistance`: "427 m" or "1.65 km"), sun %, and rain % only while it is raining. The delta line uses the backend's `extra_seconds`.

2.6 `lib/route.ts`

Pure helpers with no React and no maths, kept apart from the components: the TypeScript types of the API, constants (campus centre `[43.7735, -79.5019]`, map bounds, `DEFAULT_AVOIDANCE = 50`, `AVOID_RAIN_W = 10`, date range 1900–2100), `nowInToronto()`, `routeQuery()`, `shadowQuery()`, the validators `parseRoute / parseShadows / parseCampus`, the point-in-polygon test `insideRing()`, and `getJson()`.

Toronto time. `nowInToronto()` uses `Intl.DateTimeFormat` with `timeZone: "America/Toronto"`, so the default date and time are Toronto wall-clock time even if the judge's laptop is set to another time zone. For example: 18:07 UTC in June → 14:07 (EDT); 03:03 UTC on 15 Jan → 22:03 on 14 Jan (EST).

> **NO MATHS IN THE BROWSER**
> The frontend never calls Open-Meteo and never computes routes, sun or shadows. It only sends settings and displays what the backend returns, including the `weather` object of each `/route` response (§11).

2.7 All React state (and what is deliberately *not* state)

State (useState)	Starts as
`date`	today in Toronto
`minutes` (0–1439)	now in Toronto
`sunAvoidance` (0–100)	50
`avoidRain`	false
`start`, `end` (`LatLon | null`)	null
`placing` ("start"|"end")	"start"
`showShadows`	false
`notice` (off-campus message)	null
inside each `useRemote`: `loaded`, `error`, `attempt`	null, null, 0

Derived on every render (not state)
the request path, e.g. `/route?date=…`
`r`: the route to draw (only if both pins exist)
`stale`: does the shown data belong to an older path?
`failed`: the first error among route, shadows, campus
formatted times, distances, percentages

> **DESIGN PRINCIPLE**
> Store the minimum; compute the rest. Because the request path is a plain string computed from state, "did anything change?" is just string comparison, and the same string is the React `key` for the map layers.

3 Frontend → backend request flow

What happens between "the user moves a slider" and "the green line moves".

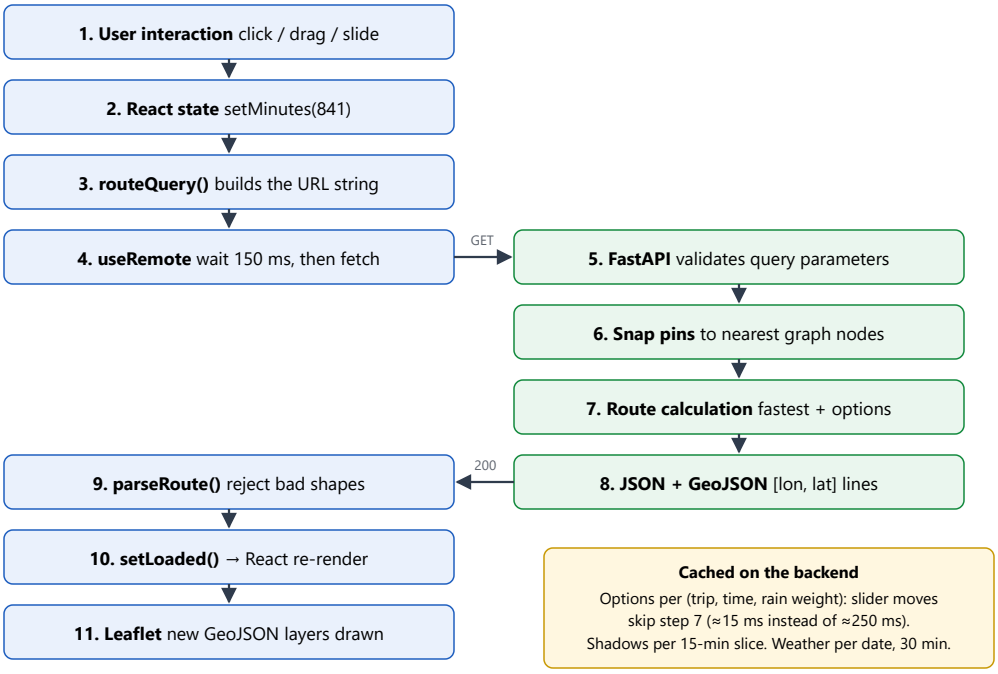


Figure 2. One request round-trip. Blue = browser, green = backend.

3.1 The URL that is actually sent

```
GET /route?date=2026-06-21&time=14:00&sun_avoidance=50&w_rain=0
          &from_lat=43.7735&from_lon=-79.5019&to_lat=43.779&to_lon=-79.496
```

`routeQuery()` sends the slider's 0–100 `sun_avoidance` as is, sends `w_rain=10` when "Avoid rain" is on (else 0), and sends pins as separate lat/lon numbers. Shadows use a different, smaller query (`shadowQuery` : only `date` and `time`), because shadows do not depend on pins, sun avoidance or rain.

3.2 The custom hook `useRemote`

`src/components/CampusMap.tsx`

```
useEffect(() => {
  if (!path) return;                       // null path = don't fetch (e.g. pins not placed)
  const controller = new AbortController();
  const timer = setTimeout(async () => {   // debounce: wait 150 ms
    try {
      const value = parse(await getJson(path, controller.signal));
      if (controller.signal.aborted) return;
      setLoaded({ path, value });          // remember WHICH path this answer belongs to
      setError(null);
    } catch (e) {
      if (controller.signal.aborted) return;
      setError({ path, message: e instanceof Error ? e.message : String(e) });
    }
  }, 150);
```

```
  return () => { clearTimeout(timer); controller.abort(); };   // cleanup
}, [path, parse, attempt]);
```

The hook returns	Meaning
`value`	the last successfully parsed answer (kept while a new one loads)
`path`	the request path that answer belongs to (used in the layers' `key`)
`stale`	`true` while the shown answer belongs to an older path: the map dims it
`error`	the error message, but only if it belongs to the *current* path
`retry()`	clears the error and bumps `attempt`, which re-runs the effect

Debounce (150 ms)

Dragging the time slider from 14:00 to 14:20 changes state 20 times. Each change re-runs the effect, whose cleanup cancels the previous timer. Only when the slider rests for 150 ms does a request go out. Result: one request instead of twenty.

AbortController

If a request is already in flight and the path changes, the cleanup calls `controller.abort()`. The browser cancels the HTTP request, and the `aborted` checks guarantee an old answer can never overwrite a newer one (no race condition).

Stale routes

`stale = loaded.path !== path`. While a new answer is loading, the old route stays on the map but is dimmed (lower opacity, Detour dashed `"6 8"`) and the panel says "Updating...". The user never sees an empty map flash.

Retry

An error is stored with its path, so it only shows while it belongs to the current request. **Retry** bumps `attempt`, a dependency of the effect, which re-runs the fetch. It retries *only* what failed: the route, the shadows, or the campus outline (which fails if the page loads before the backend is up).

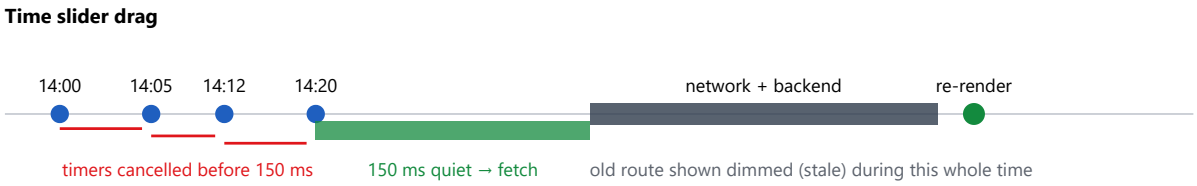


Figure 3. Debounce timeline: four changes, one request.

3.3 API validation: `getJson` and `parseRoute`

- **`getJson`** turns failures into human messages: network failure → "*can't reach the backend at http://localhost:8000*"; HTTP 422/404 → the backend's `detail` text (e.g. "*start is outside York University's Keele Campus*"); an abort is re-thrown untouched so the hook can ignore it.
- **`parseRoute`** checks that the JSON really has finite numbers for each route's seconds, distance, sun % and rain %, a geometry object, the extra seconds, the number of options and a known weather source: exactly the fields the UI uses. If not, it throws "*unexpected /route response*", which is shown as an error instead of crashing the page during rendering. `isNum` rejects `NaN` and `Infinity`.

LIKELY QUESTION

"What happens if the backend is asleep?" The free Render plan sleeps after 15 min; the first request waits about a minute while it wakes. If a request fails, the panel shows the error and a Retry button. The map, pins and controls keep working.

4 Leaflet and mapping

4.1 Leaflet vs OpenStreetMap

OPENSTREETMAP (OSM)

A free, community-made **map database** of the world. We use it twice: (1) the background **tile images** from `tile.openstreetmap.org`, and (2) the **data** the backend downloaded once with OSMnx: footpaths, the campus boundary (OSM way 15396822) and tree locations.

LEAFLET

A JavaScript **library** that displays an interactive map in the browser: panning, zooming, tiles, markers, lines and polygons. **react-leaflet** wraps Leaflet so each map layer is a React component.

4.2 Components used

Component	Our settings
`MapContainer`	centre `[43.7735, -79.5019]`, zoom 16, `minZoom` 15, `maxBounds` = campus box `[[43.764,-79.525],[43.785,-79.488]]` with viscosity 1 (cannot pan away), scroll-wheel zoom
`TileLayer`	OSM tiles + required attribution "© OpenStreetMap contributors"
`Pane`	Custom drawing layers with a z-index (stacking order), see Figure 4
`Polygon`	Grey "outside campus" mask (a big box with the campus cut out as a hole) + orange dashed campus outline
`GeoJSON`	Routes (LineStrings) and shadows (one MultiPolygon), straight from the backend
`Polyline`	Short dotted "connector" lines from each pin to where the route starts/ends on the path network
`Marker`	Start and end pins: custom `divIcon`, `draggable`, with a `Tooltip`
`useMapEvents`	Map click → place the next pin (`ClickToPlace`)
`ZoomControl`, `ScaleControl`	+/− buttons top-left, scale bar bottom-left

4.3 Layer order (what is drawn on top of what)

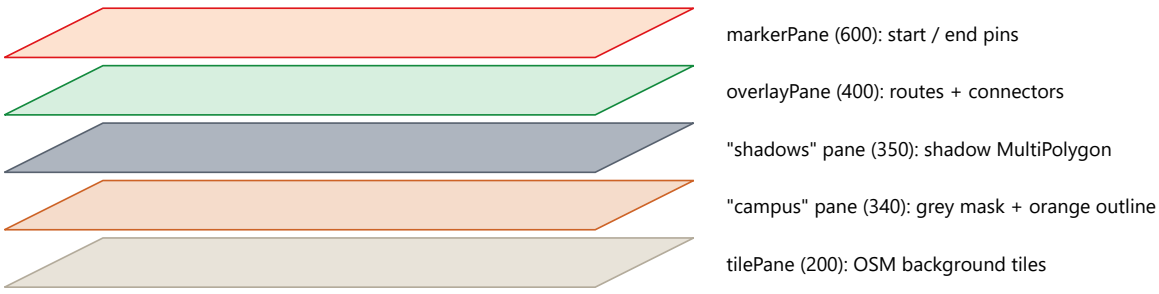


Figure 4. Leaflet panes, bottom to top. Shadows sit below the overlay pane, so they can never cover a route.

Route casing (the white outline)

Each route is drawn twice: first a wider **white** line (the "casing"), then the coloured line on top, so the route stands out over any map colour. Order: fastest casing (white, 8.5 px) → fastest (red `#e0161b`, 5 px, dotted `"1 9"`) → Detour casing (white, 11 px) → Detour (green `#138a3e`, 7 px). Detour is drawn last, so it is the "hero" line on top.

Why GeoJSON layers have a `key`

react-leaflet's `<GeoJSON>` ignores later changes to its `data` prop. Each layer's `key` includes the request path (e.g. `key={`ctx-${route.path}`}`), so when a new answer arrives React throws the old layer away and creates a new one. Style changes such as stale dimming are still applied through the `style` prop.

Shadows: drawn only when needed

The shadow request path is `null` while "Show shadows" is off, so nothing is fetched. When on, the backend sends one MultiPolygon of overlapping pieces (≈1.45 MB at midday); Leaflet draws it with `fillRule: "nonzero"`, which fills overlapping pieces once, so it looks exactly like the merged shadow without the backend having to merge thousands of polygons.

Draggable pins and the campus rule

Pins can only be placed inside the campus polygon. The frontend checks with `insideRing()` (ray casting: count how many polygon edges a horizontal ray from the point crosses; odd = inside). A pin dragged outside is put back where it was, and a message appears. The backend checks the same polygon again (it never trusts the client) and answers 422 for an off-campus pin. Any pin inside the campus is accepted, however far it is from a path: it snaps to the nearest walkway node and a dotted line joins it to the route.

4.4 Coordinate order: the most common bug in mapping

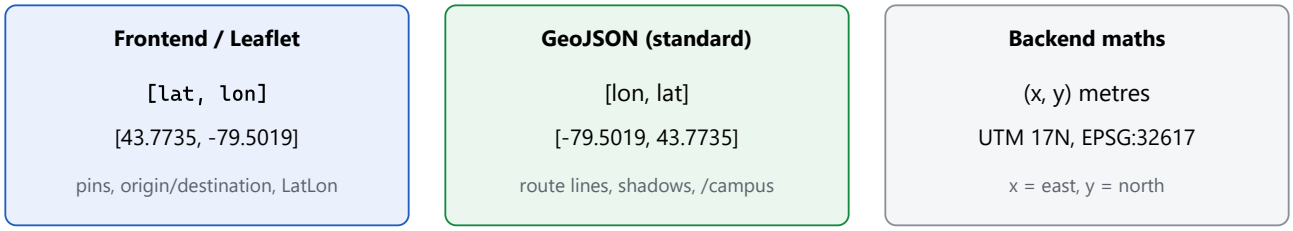


Figure 5. Three coordinate systems. Lat/lon are angles; the backend converts to metres so lengths and shadows are in metres.

Where the swaps happen in code: `parseCampus` maps `([lon, lat]) => [lat, lon]`; `lineEnds` reads `[a[1], a[0]]`; the Leaflet `GeoJSON` component reads `[lon, lat]` itself; the backend's pyproj transformers use `always_xy=True` (x = longitude first). `origin` / `destination` in the response are `[lat, lon]`. During development a test checked that the first route coordinate has `-80 < lon < -79` and `43 < lat < 44`.

5 Backend: FastAPI and data

5.1 FastAPI in one paragraph

FastAPI turns Python functions into HTTP endpoints. The function's parameters become query parameters, and their types and limits are validated automatically: `sun_avoidance: float = Query(50.0, ge=0, le=100)` means a request with `sun_avoidance=101` is rejected with HTTP 422 before our code runs. Response models (`RouteResponse`, Pydantic) guarantee the JSON shape. FastAPI also generates interactive docs at `/docs`.

5.2 Endpoints

Endpoint	Parameters	Returns
`GET /route`	`date` (1900-01-01..2100-12-31), `time` (HH:MM Toronto), `sun_avoidance` 0–100 (default 50), `w_rain` 0–50 (default 0), `from_lat/from_lon/to_lat/to_lon` (optional, default = demo trip), `clear_sky` (demo option; the UI never sends it)	Both routes (time, distance, sun %, sun-seconds, rain %, GeoJSON line), sun position, weather, `route_options`, `extra_seconds`, changes in sun/rain %
`GET /shadows`	`date`, `time`	GeoJSON FeatureCollection with one MultiPolygon (empty at night)
`GET /campus`	none	GeoJSON Feature: the campus boundary polygon
`GET/HEAD /health`	none	`{"status":"ok","edges":5172,"buildings":737}` (HEAD too, for uptime monitors)
`GET /docs`	none	Auto-generated interactive API docs

Error codes: **422** for invalid input (bad time, out-of-range date, pin outside campus, only one of lat/lon). A **404** (no route) cannot happen for pins on campus, because the walk graph is one strongly connected component. CORS allows `localhost:3000` plus the sites in the `ALLOWED_ORIGINS` environment variable; only GET is allowed.

5.3 What one `/route` request does, step by step

`backend/api.py, get_route() (simplified)`

```
origin_node = _snap("start", from_lat, from_lon)     # pin → nearest graph node (422 if off campus)
dest_node = _snap("end", to_lat, to_lon)
when = _parse_when(date, time)                        # Toronto local time, 1900–2100
model = _model_for(when, clear_sky)                   # sun + weather for that date (cached)
fast, options = _options_for(model, origin_node, dest_node, when, w_rain)   # cached per trip
ctx = pick(options, sun_avoidance / 100)              # the Detour route
```

1. **Validate.** FastAPI checks every query parameter's type and range before any of our code runs (422 if wrong).
2. **Snap the pins.** Each pin is converted to metres, checked against the campus polygon, and replaced by its nearest graph node (§6.1).

3. **Pick the model.** `_model_for` returns the exposure model for that date: live Open-Meteo weather (refetched every 30 min) or a clear sky.
4. **Find the routes.** `route()` gives the fastest route (pure walking time); `shade_options()` gives every time/shade trade-off (§7.4). Both are cached, so moving only the avoidance slider skips this step.
5. **Choose.** `pick()` takes the quickest option that removes the requested share of the avoidable sun (§7.5).
6. **Answer.** Each route's edges are joined into one line, converted to longitude/latitude (GeoJSON) and sent with time, distance, sun %, rain %, the weather and the sun position.

5.4 Start-up (the `lifespan` function)

1. `load_campus()` reads the cached files in `backend/cache/` (no internet needed): the walk graph, 737 building footprints with heights, 1,181 trees and the campus polygon. (If the cache were missing it would download from OSM via Overpass, rotating 3 mirror servers with exponential back-off.)
2. Builds the base `ExposureModel`: places **121,632 sample points** every 1.5 m along all edges, indexes them in an STRtree, and computes each edge's rain shelter fraction. This is done **once**.
3. Indexes the 1,804 graph nodes in a Shapely STRtree (for snapping pins), snaps the demo trip's endpoints and creates empty caches.

Uvicorn only opens the port after this finishes, which is why the frontend can briefly report "can't reach the backend" during start-up (then Retry).

5.5 Caches (static data loaded once, results reused)

Cache	Key	Bound	Why
Campus data, edge table, sample points, shelter	—	loaded once	Never changes while running
Exposure model per day	(date, clear_sky)	cleared above 32	Sun schedule for a date; rebuilt when the weather refreshes
Route options	(model, origin, dest, time, w_rain)	cleared above 64	Moving only the avoidance slider re-picks from cached options
Shade fractions *f*	15-min slice	192 slices	Shadows change slowly; shared by all models
`/shadows` response bodies	15-min slice	64 slices	A midday body is ≈ 1.45 MB, so 64 keeps the server well inside its 512 MB
Spatial index of the graph nodes	—	built once	Snaps a pin to its nearest node in microseconds
Weather per date	date	30 min (60 s after a failure)	Respect the free API, keep requests fast

5.6 Where the data comes from

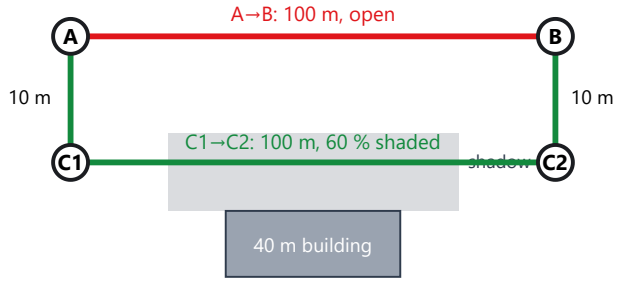
Data	Source	Numbers
Walk network	OSM via OSMnx, `network_type="walk"`, campus + 100 m buffer, projected to UTM 17N	1,804 nodes, 5,172 directed edges
Campus boundary	OSM way 15396822 "York University, Keele Campus"	one polygon
Buildings	City of Toronto 3D Massing 2025 (packaged in `backend/data/`), height = `MAX_HEIGHT`	737 footprints, tallest 61.5 m
Trees	OSM `natural=tree` points within 300 m of campus	1,181 trees

6 Graph theory

A map of walkways is a graph. Routing is "find the best path through a graph".

$$G = (V, E)$$

Term	Meaning in Detour
Vertex (node) $v \in V$	A point where walkways meet or end. Has metric coordinates x, y. |V| = 1,804.
Edge $e = (u, v) \in E$	A walkway segment from u to v, with a length in metres and its exact curved geometry. |E| = 5,172.
Directed	Each walkway is stored in both directions (u→v and v→u), because shade is computed per edge entered at a time.
Multigraph	Two nodes may be joined by several different walkways (`key` 0, 1, …). NetworkX `MultiDiGraph` .
Path P	A sequence of edges e_1, e_2, …, e_k where each ends where the next begins.
Weight / cost	A number per edge; the cost of a path is the sum of its edge costs.
Shortest path	The path from origin to destination with the smallest total cost.



Sun due south: the shadow falls north, over the middle of the detour.

Figure 6. A small toy graph (worked through in §7.6).

WHY THE GRAPH IS PROJECTED TO METRES

OSM stores degrees. One degree of longitude at Toronto is only about 80 km, but one degree of latitude is about 111 km, so distances in degrees are distorted. Projecting to UTM zone 17N (EPSG:32617) makes x and y true metres, so *length*, *straight-line distance* and shadow offsets are all directly in metres.

6.1 Snapping a pin to the graph

A clicked point is usually not exactly on a node. `_snap()` in `api.py` converts the point to metres, checks it is on campus, and finds the closest node with a Shapely STRtree built once at start-up, however far away that node is. The walk graph is one strongly connected component (every node can reach every other), so any two pins always have a route. The dotted connector lines on the map show the gap between a pin and the node its route starts from.

7 Routing mathematics and algorithms

7.1 The edge cost (router.py)

$$\text{cost}(e, t) = \tau_e + w_r \cdot W_e(t) \quad \text{and, as a separate second criterion, sun } S_e(t)$$

Symbol	Meaning	Unit	Value in the app
$\tau_e = d_e / v$	time to walk edge e (length d_e, speed v)	seconds	v = 1.4 m/s
$S_e(t)$	sun exposure on e if entered at time t (§10)	sun-seconds	second criterion (§7.4)
$W_e(t)$	rain exposure on e if entered at time t (§12)	rain-seconds	computed
w_r	seconds of walking traded per rain-second	s / rain-s	0, or 10 with "Avoid rain"

Both terms are in seconds, so the weight has a plain meaning: "*how many seconds of extra walking would I accept to avoid one second out in moderate rain?*" Sun has no weight in the cost: adding $w_s \cdot S_e$ is the obvious idea, but §7.4 shows why Detour treats sun as a second criterion instead, and §7.6 works through what a sun weight would do.

7.2 Dijkstra's algorithm

Keep a priority queue (a heap) of nodes ordered by the best known cost from the origin. Repeatedly take the cheapest node, mark it settled, and try every outgoing edge: if going through it is cheaper than what a neighbour had, update the neighbour. When the destination is settled, follow the "came from" links backwards to get the path. With non-negative edge costs, the first time a node is settled its cost is optimal.

7.3 A* = Dijkstra + a good guess

A* orders the heap by *cost so far* $+ h(n)$, where $h(n)$ is a lower bound on the remaining cost. Detour uses straight-line walking time:

$$\text{h(n)} = 0.99 \cdot \frac{\text{straight-line distance(n, goal)}}{1.4 \text{ m/s}}$$

- No walkway can be shorter than the straight line, and every edge costs at least its walking time (the rain term is ≥ 0), so h never overestimates: it is **admissible** and **consistent**. A* therefore returns exactly the same route cost as Dijkstra (checked on the real campus during development).
- The 0.99 "slack" is because OSM edge lengths can be a hair shorter than the projected straight line (measured ratio ≥ 0.9975).
- Benefit, measured on the demo trip during development (21 June, 14:00): **A* settled 876 nodes vs Dijkstra's 1,703**, about half the work.

Time-dependence: *S* and *W* depend on the time you enter an edge, so each search label carries its arrival time. Settling by accumulated cost is exact only if arriving earlier never makes the rest of the walk costlier; over a walk of minutes the sun barely moves, so the error is negligible (documented assumption).

7.4 How the app really picks the Detour route: the Pareto set

A single weight $time + w_s \cdot sun$ only finds routes on the *convex hull* of the time-vs-sun trade-off, so the route "jumps" as the weight changes and some good compromises are never chosen. So Detour has no sun weight. Instead `shade_options()` finds the **Pareto set**: every route that no other route beats on *both* time and sun.

- **Algorithm:** bicriteria label-setting (Martins' algorithm) with A* keys. A node may hold several labels (cost, sun, arrival time). Labels pop in cost order; a new label at a node is kept only if its sun is lower than every label already kept there.
- **Criterion 1:** $c = \tau + w_r \cdot W$ (time, plus rain if Avoid rain is on).
- **Criterion 2:** sun-seconds S.
- **Limit 1 (`MAX_DETOUR = 0.5`):** options may cost at most 50 % more than the quickest.
- **Limit 2 (`SUN_STEP = 0.02`):** each new option must cut sun by at least 2 % of the quickest route's sun (and at least 1 sun-second), so near-identical routes aren't counted.

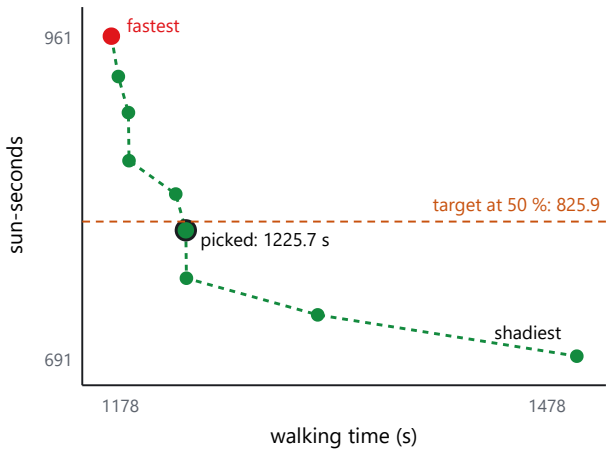


Figure 7. The 9 Pareto options of the demo trip (21 June 14:00, clear-sky model). Every point is a real route.

backend/router.py, inside shade_options(): the domination rule

```
# labels are (cost, sun, arrival time) at node u, popped from the heap in cost order
if sun > least_sun.get(u, inf) - step or sun > least_sun.get(dest, inf) - step:
    continue              # a cheaper label here (or an option already found) gets about as little sun
least_sun[u] = sun        # keep it: the least sun seen at u so far
if u == dest:
    found.append(...)     # a new option, costlier but shadier than the previous one
```

Because labels come out in cost order, every label that survives is a new trade-off: more cost, less sun. When the destination is reached, the label's chain of parent labels is followed back to rebuild the route.

7.5 The slider: `pick()`

backend/router.py

```
def pick(options, avoidance):          # avoidance = sun_avoidance / 100, so 0..1
    most, least = options[0].sun_seconds, options[-1].sun_seconds
    target = most - avoidance * (most - least)
    return next(r for r in options if r.sun_seconds <= target + 1e-9)
```

$$\text{target} = S_{\text{fastest}} - p \cdot (S_{\text{fastest}} - S_{\text{shadiest}}) \quad \text{then choose the } \textbf{quickest} \text{ option with } S \le \text{target}$$

Sun avoidance p means "avoid at least p of the sun that *can* be avoided on this trip". 0 % = fastest, 100 % = shadiest option. Options are already sorted quickest-first, so the first one that meets the target is the quickest that does.

7.6 Worked example 1: the toy graph (real numbers from the code)

Sun at 13:15 on 21 June: elevation 69.6°, azimuth 176.8°; clear-sky intensity $I = \sin 69.6° = 0.938$. The middle detour edge is 59.7 % shaded.

Edge	Length	τ = d / 1.4	shade f	S = τ · I · (1 − f)
A→B	100 m	71.43 s	0	66.97
A→C1	10 m	7.14 s	0	6.70
C1→C2	100 m	71.43 s	0.597	26.99
C2→B	10 m	7.14 s	0	6.70

Left: the two routes. Right: what a single sun weight would choose, with cost = T + w_s·S.

Route	Time T	Sun S	Sun %
Direct A→B	71.4 s	66.97	100 %
Detour A→C1→C2→B	85.7 s	40.38	50.2 %

w_s	Direct cost	Detour cost	Winner
0.5	71.4 + 33.5 = **104.9**	85.7 + 20.2 = 105.9	Direct
1	71.4 + 67.0 = 138.4	85.7 + 40.4 = **126.1**	Detour

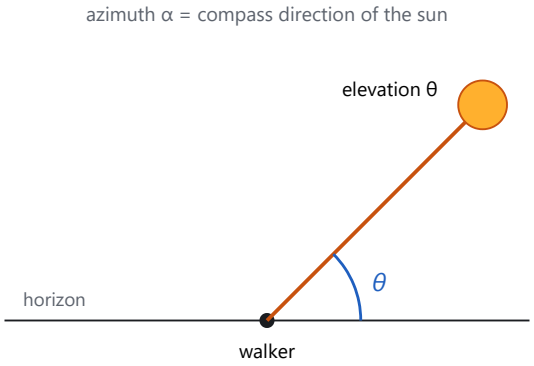
Interpretation: the detour costs 14.3 s more and avoids 26.6 sun-seconds. It is worth it only if you value a sun-second at more than 14.3 / 26.6 ≈ 0.54 s of walking. With the slider, the Pareto set here has 2 options, so any avoidance above 0 % picks the detour.

7.7 Worked example 2: the real demo trip at 50 %

$S_{fastest}$ = 961.3, $S_{shadiest}$ = 690.5 (sun-seconds). Target = 961.3 − 0.5 × 270.8 = **825.9**. The quickest option with S ≤ 825.9 has S = 797.1, T = 1,225.7 s vs 1,177.7 s fastest: **+48 s of walking, sun 88.5 % → 70.6 %**.

8 Sun position

Quantity	Definition (backend convention)
Elevation θ	Angle of the sun above the horizon. 0° = on the horizon, 90° = straight overhead.
Azimuth α	Compass direction of the sun, degrees clockwise from north: 90° = east, 180° = south, 270° = west.
Daylight	`is_up` : elevation > 0°.



Computed with **pvlib** (NREL's Solar Position Algorithm) for the campus centre (43.7735° N, 79.5019° W), using *apparent* elevation (includes atmospheric refraction). For speed, `SunSchedule` computes all 1,441 minutes of a day once (00:00…24:00) and then just looks values up.

8.1 Real values at York (from the code)

Date and time (Toronto)	Elevation	Azimuth	Comment
21 June, 09:00	33.8°	88.7°	morning sun from the east
21 June, 13:15	69.6°	176.8°	near solar noon (EDT shifts noon past 13:00)
21 June, 18:00	30.1°	274.7°	evening sun from the west
20 March, 13:20	46.3°	178.1°	equinox: 90° − latitude ≈ 46.2°
21 December, 12:15	22.8°	179.7°	winter: low sun, long shadows

TORONTO LOCAL TIME VS UTC

All dates/times in the API are Toronto wall-clock time (`ZoneInfo("America/Toronto")` , EDT = UTC−4 in summer, EST = UTC−5 in winter). They are converted to UTC only when calling pvlib. Sun positions were checked on both DST-change days during development.

LIKELY QUESTION

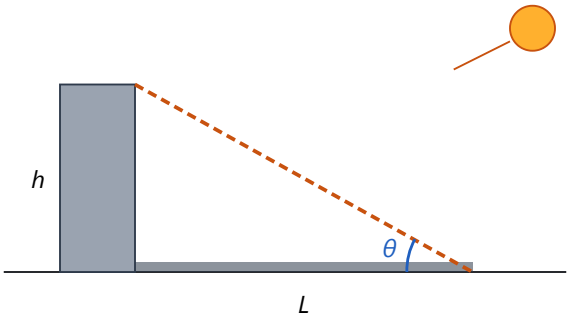
"Why not compute the sun once for the whole route?" The router does use the time each edge is entered, but sun position changes only ~0.25° per minute, so shadows are recomputed every 15 minutes (nearest slice), while sun *intensity* is interpolated to the second.

9 Shadow mathematics

9.1 Shadow length

$$L = \frac{h}{\tan(\theta)}$$

In plain English: the sun ray from the top of a building of height *h* hits the ground a distance *L* away. The ray, the wall and the ground make a right-angled triangle; tan(θ) = opposite / adjacent = *h* / *L*, so *L* = *h* / tan(θ). The lower the sun, the smaller tan(θ), the longer the shadow.



Sun elevation θ	tan θ	Shadow of a 20 m building	Shadow of the tallest (61.5 m)
69.6° (June noon)	2.69	7.4 m	22.9 m
46.3° (equinox noon)	1.05	19.1 m	58.8 m
30°	0.577	34.6 m	106.6 m
22.8° (Dec noon)	0.420	47.6 m	146.4 m
3° (cut-off)	0.052	381.6 m → capped at 300 m	capped at 300 m

Two safety rules from `shadow.py`: below **3°** no shadows are computed (tan θ → 0 makes L → ∞ and the model stops being meaningful); every shadow is capped at **300 m**.

9.2 Shadow direction

The shadow points away from the sun. With azimuth α measured clockwise from north (x = east, y = north), the ground offset of the roof is:

$$(\Delta x, \Delta y) = (\,-L\cdot\sin\alpha,\ -L\cdot\cos\alpha\,)$$

Check: sun due south (α = 180°): sin = 0, cos = −1 → (0, +L): shadow points north ✓. Sun in the east (α = 90°): (−L, 0): shadow points west ✓ (both were checked by unit tests during development).

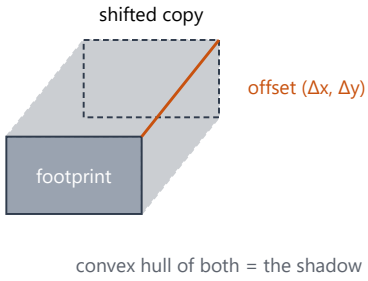
`backend/shadow.py (inside ShadowCaster.pieces)`

```
tan_el = math.tan(math.radians(sun.elevation))      # degrees -> radians before tan!
alpha = math.radians(sun.azimuth)
direction = np.array([-math.sin(alpha), -math.cos(alpha)])
high = np.minimum(self._cvx_h / tan_el, MAX_SHADOW_LENGTH_M)   # L = h / tan(theta), capped
```

9.3 From one point to a whole building

A building is modelled as a **prism**: its footprint polygon extruded straight up to height *h*. Its shadow on flat ground is the footprint **swept** along the offset vector.

- **Convex footprints** (area ≥ 98 % of their convex hull, no holes): shadow = convex hull of the footprint and its shifted copy. Computed for all such buildings in one vectorised call.
- **Concave footprints** (L, U shapes, courtyards): a hull would wrongly fill the courtyard, so each wall edge sweeps a parallelogram; shadow = footprint + all parallelograms. During development a unit test confirmed that a U-shaped building keeps its sunlit gap.



9.4 Trees

OSM trees have no size data, so every tree gets the same crown: a 12-sided disk of radius **3 m** floating from **2 m** (canopy base) to **9 m** (top); the trunk is ignored. The crown base casts its shadow 2 / tan θ away and the top 9 / tan θ away; the tree's shadow is the convex hull of those two shifted disks. Consequence: the ground directly under a tree is shaded only when the sun is high (checked: shaded at 89°, not at 20°, where the base shadow is 2 / tan 20° ≈ 5.5 m away, beyond the 3 m crown).

9.5 Which walkway parts are in shadow?

Sample points every **1.5 m** along each edge (at least 2 per edge; 121,632 in total). For each 15-minute time slice, the shadow pieces are tested against an STRtree of those points. The **shade fraction** is:

$$f(e) = \frac{\text{number of e's sample points inside any shadow}}{\text{number of e's sample points}}$$

During development a test compared this to exact line-polygon overlap on the whole campus at 9:00, 13:00 and 17:00: the length-weighted difference was under 0.5 percentage points. Walkways inside building footprints count as fully shaded (indoor connections).

10 Exposure mathematics and units

10.1 Sun intensity *I*(*t*)

$$I(t) = \frac{\text{direct radiation}(t)\ \ [\mathrm{W/m^2}]}{1000\ \mathrm{W/m^2}} \quad \text{(live weather)} \quad \text{or} \quad I(t) = \max(0, \sin\theta(t)) \quad \text{(clear-sky fallback)}$$

Shade only blocks the **direct beam**; diffuse skylight reaches you in the shade too. So intensity uses Open-Meteo's *direct* radiation, not total sunlight. Under full overcast the direct beam is ~0, so there is nothing to avoid, and the Detour and Fastest routes coincide. This is how **clouds affect routing**: through direct radiation, not through the cloud-cover number.

10.2 Sun-seconds on one edge

$$S_e = \int_{t_e}^{t_e+\tau_e} I(t)\cdot(1-f)\,dt \;\approx\; \tau_e \cdot \frac{I(t_e) + I(t_e+\tau_e)}{2} \cdot (1-f)$$

A **sun-second** is one second spent in full-strength direct sun (*I* = 1, no shade). The integral is approximated with the trapezoid rule (average of the intensity at entry and exit), and *f* comes from the nearest 15-minute shadow slice.

WORKED EXAMPLE

A 14 m edge: τ = 14 / 1.4 = 10 s. Intensity 0.80 at entry, 0.82 at exit, shade f = 0.25.
S = 10 × (0.80 + 0.82)/2 × (1 − 0.25) = 10 × 0.81 × 0.75 = **6.08 sun-seconds**.

10.3 Route totals and "Sun %"

$$T = \Sigma\,\tau_e \quad S(P) = \Sigma\,S_e \quad S_{open}(P) = \Sigma\,S_e \text{ with } f = 0 \quad \text{sun \%} = 100 \times S(P) \,/\, S_{open}(P)$$

Each edge is entered at the time you actually reach it (start time + time walked so far). **Sun %** = the share of the sun this path *could* give you that it actually gives you. It is about shade, not weather: if intensity is the same everywhere, it cancels, and sun % ≈ the time-weighted share of the walk that is unshaded. At night or under full overcast, S_{open} = 0 and sun % is defined as 0.

PERCENT VS FRACTION: EXACT CONVENTIONS

Quantity	UI shows	Sent / returned	Used in maths as
Sun avoidance	50 %	`sun_avoidance=50`	0.5 (`/ 100` in `api.py`)
Sun % of a route	78 %	`"sun_percent": 78.4` (already %)	computed as 100 × S / S_{open}
Cloud cover	Cloud 70 %	`"cloud_cover": 0.7` (fraction)	display only
Shade fraction f, shelter g	—	not sent	0–1
Intensity I, rain R	—	not sent	0–1 (I can slightly exceed 1)

10.4 Unit table

Quantity	Unit	Note
distance, length, shadow length	metres	UI shows km above 1,000 m
time τ, T, `extra_seconds`	seconds	UI formats as "7 min 18 sec"; time of day is minutes after midnight (0–1439) in the frontend
speed	m/s	constant 1.4 m/s ≈ 5 km/h
angles	degrees in API/UI	converted to radians (`math.radians`) before sin/tan
radiation	W/m²	divided by 1000 for intensity
precipitation	mm/h	divided by 4 and capped at 1 for rain intensity

11 Weather

Question	Answer (from `weather.py` and `api.py`)
Provider	**Open-Meteo** (free, no API key). Forecast API (about 3 months back to 16 days ahead), then the archive API for older dates.
Variables fetched	Hourly `direct_radiation` (W/m²), `cloud_cover` (%), `precipitation` (mm) for one day, Toronto time zone.
Who calls it	Only the backend, inside `/route` . The frontend never calls Open-Meteo.
Refresh timing	Cached per date for **30 minutes**; after a failed fetch it retries after **60 seconds**; each HTTP call times out after **5 s**.
Time resolution	Radiation and precipitation are averages over the hour *ending* at each timestamp, so they are placed at the middle of that hour (−30 min) and linearly interpolated to the minute. Cloud cover is instantaneous and interpolated at the hour.
Fallback	If both APIs fail (or the date is out of their range, e.g. before 1940 or months ahead), weather = none: intensity = clear-sky sin θ, no rain; the panel says "*Weather unavailable, assuming clear sky.*" `clear_sky=true` forces this for demos.
Shown to the user	"Cloud 0 % · direct sun 488 W/m² · rain 0 mm/h (live, Open-Meteo)" under the route.

11.1 What actually affects routing

Variable	Affects routing?	How
direct_radiation	Yes	Sun intensity I(t) → sun-seconds → which Pareto options exist and which one the slider picks
precipitation	Only with Avoid rain	Rain intensity R(t) → rain-seconds, weighted by $w_r = 10$
cloud_cover	No	Display only (clouds still matter, via lower direct radiation)

backend/weather.py

```
minutes = np.arange(24 * 60 + 1)
at_hour = np.arange(24) * 60.0
mid_hour = at_hour - 30.0  # radiation and precipitation are averages over the preceding hour
direct=np.interp(minutes, mid_hour, values["direct_radiation"])
```

HONEST CAVEAT

One weather point (campus centre) is used for the whole campus. Open-Meteo uses a single UTC offset per day, so on the two DST-change days the weather after 02:00 can be an hour out (the sun position is still exact).

12 Rain

Rain routing **is** implemented, but it only changes the route when two things are both true: "Avoid rain" is on *and* the forecast has rain at that time.

RAIN DISPLAYED

- Weather line always shows `rain … mm/h` (live weather).
- Each route card shows a **Rain %** row only while it is raining at the departure time (`rain_mm_h > 0`).
- The switch caption says "No rain at this time" when the forecast is dry.

RAIN AFFECTING ROUTING

- "Avoid rain" sends `w_rain=10` (else 0).
- The Detour options then use cost $c = \tau + 10 \cdot W$.
- The **Fastest** route is always pure time; it never avoids rain.
- No rain in the forecast → W = 0 → no effect.

12.1 Rain maths

$$R(t) = \min(1, \text{rain}(t) \,/\, 4\ \text{mm/h}) \qquad W_e = \int R(t) \cdot (1 - g(e))\, dt \approx \tau_e \cdot \frac{R(t_e) + R(t_e + \tau_e)}{2} \cdot (1 - g(e))$$

- **R**: rain intensity 0–1; moderate rain (4 mm/h) or heavier counts as 1.
- **g(e)**: the edge's **shelter** fraction: share of its 1.5 m sample points inside a building footprint, or 1 if OSM tags it as roofed (`covered=yes/arcade/colonnade`, `indoor=yes/corridor`, `highway=corridor`, `tunnel=building_passage/yes`). 364 directed edges are more than half sheltered.
- **w_r = 10**: accept up to 10 s of extra walking per rain-second.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Raining 2 mm/h → R = 0.5. Open 30 s edge: W = 30 × 0.5 = 15 rain-s → cost 30 + 10 × 15 = **180**. Covered 45 s corridor (g = 1): W = 0 → cost **45**. The router takes the corridor.

LIMITS

Rain is assumed to fall straight down (wind ignored). Indoor connections are assumed open. Rain % in the UI uses the rain at departure time to decide whether to show the row; routing integrates rain along the whole walk.

13 Testing and verification

How we know the routes and numbers are right.

Check	What it proves	Result
Lint: `npm run lint`	ESLint with the Next.js rules: no unused code, correct React hook dependencies, no common mistakes.	0 problems
Build: `npm run build`	TypeScript type-checks every file (e.g. a string passed where a number is expected fails), then the page is prerendered.	success
Automated tests (during development)	15 frontend and 60 backend tests, listed below. They are not kept in the final repository.	75 / 75 passed
Before/after comparison	Before the final code cleanup, 756 API requests (routes at many times and pins, shadows, errors, live weather) were recorded and compared with the cleaned-up code: byte-for-byte identical. A scripted browser click-through showed an identical page.	identical

13.1 What the automated tests checked

Routing

- The fastest route equals NetworkX's shortest path ÷ 1.4 m/s on 10 random campus pairs.
- A* returns the same cost as Dijkstra while settling fewer nodes.
- Pareto options are strictly slower and shadier, stay within the 50 % cap, and include every route a weighted sum could find.
- `pick()` thresholds; a toy graph with a known answer takes the shade detour.
- Under overcast there is nothing to avoid; rain shelter and OSM tags work.

Sun and shadows

- Shadow direction: sun in the south → shadow north; sun in the east → shadow west.
- L = h / tan θ at 30°; the 300 m cap; no shadow below 3°.
- A U-shaped building keeps its sunlit courtyard; tree shadow geometry.
- 1.5 m sampling within 0.5 percentage points of exact geometry over the whole campus.

API and weather

- Response shape; GeoJSON in [lon, lat] order; day vs night; 0 % avoidance = fastest.
- 422 for bad input and off-campus pins; date range; CORS.
- Weather interpolated to the minute with hour averages at mid-hour; rain saturates at 4 mm/h; offline → clear-sky fallback.
- Both DST-change days line up.

Frontend

- The URL carries every input in backend units; only date and time change the shadow URL.
- Malformed responses are rejected with a clear message; empty night-time shadows parse.
- Toronto time in summer and winter; campus parsing and point-in-polygon.

LIKELY QUESTION

"Where are your tests?" Honest answer: we wrote and ran 75 automated tests during development, and they all passed on the final code; we left them out of the final repository to keep it small. Lint and the type-checked build still run, and the final cleanup was checked by comparing 756 API answers before and after.

14 Limitations (honest list)

Physical model

- Flat ground; constant walking speed 1.4 m/s (no stairs, slopes or crowds).
- "Heat" = direct-sun exposure only. No air temperature, humidity, wind, or heat from pavement.
- Buildings are prisms at their **maximum** height (Toronto `MAX_HEIGHT`), which overestimates shadows of buildings with lower wings.
- All trees are the same size (3 m crown, 2–9 m high); OSM may miss trees; leaves are assumed present all year.
- Shadows only from buildings and trees; no awnings, bridges or overhangs (unless tagged covered).
- No shadows below 3° elevation; length capped at 300 m.
- Shade sampled every 1.5 m; shadows from the nearest 15-minute slice.
- Indoor connections assumed open and fully shaded/sheltered at any hour.

Data and weather

- One weather point for the campus; hourly data interpolated.
- Weather only for dates Open-Meteo covers; otherwise clear-sky fallback (clearly labelled).
- DST-change days: weather can be an hour out after 02:00.
- Rain is vertical; wind-blown rain ignored.

Algorithm

- Time-dependent search assumes leaving earlier never hurts (negligible error over minutes).
- Options capped at 50 % extra cost; options must differ by ≥ 2 % of the fastest route's sun. A trip may have only 1–2 options, so the slider can do nothing over a range.

Product and engineering

- Keele Campus only; pins must be inside the campus. The dotted link from a pin to the nearest path is not counted in the route's time or distance.
- Free Render plan sleeps after 15 min; first request then waits ~1 min.
- Single backend process with in-memory caches (cleared wholesale when full).
- No automated tests in the final repository (§13); no mobile GPS or live turn-by-turn navigation.

15 Judge Q&A

Short, accurate answers. Say "I don't know, but here's how I'd find out" rather than guess.

FRONTEND AND REACT

Q1. Why Next.js and not plain React?
It gives us a build system, TypeScript, optimised fonts and images, and a static prerendered page shell for free. The interactive map is a client component loaded only in the browser.

Q2. What is state in your app?
Date, minutes, sun avoidance, avoid rain, the two pins, which pin is being placed, show shadows and the off-campus notice; plus each `useRemote`'s loaded value, error and retry counter. Everything else (request paths, stale flags, formatted numbers) is derived on each render.

Q3. Why is the map loaded with `dynamic(..., {ssr: false})`?
Leaflet uses `window` at import time, which doesn't exist during server rendering. So the server sends a placeholder and the browser loads the map.

Q4. What does `useEffect` do in `useRemote`?
It starts a 150 ms timer and then fetches. Its cleanup clears the timer and aborts the request, so every change of the request path cancels the previous one.

Q5. How do you stop an old response overwriting a new one?
Each request has an AbortController that is aborted when the path changes, and the code checks `signal.aborted` before setting state. Results are also stored with the path they belong to.

Q6. What is a controlled input?
An input whose value comes from React state and whose `onChange` updates that state, like our sliders, date picker and switches. React state is the single source of truth.

Q7. How do you validate the API response?
`parseRoute` checks the type of every field the UI uses (finite numbers, geometry object, known weather source) and throws a clear error otherwise. During development it was tested with malformed responses.

LEAFLET AND MAPPING

Q8. What is the difference between Leaflet and OpenStreetMap?
OSM is the data (and free tile images); Leaflet is the JavaScript library that shows an interactive map in the browser.

Q9. Why are coordinates sometimes [lat, lon] and sometimes [lon, lat]?
Leaflet uses [lat, lon]; the GeoJSON standard uses [lon, lat] (x before y). We convert in `parseCampus` and `lineEnds`, and during development a backend test checked the GeoJSON order.

Q10. How do you make sure shadows don't cover the route?
Shadows live in a custom Leaflet pane with z-index 350, below the overlay pane (400) where routes are drawn, and above the campus mask pane (340).

Q11. Why does the route have a white border?
It is a "casing": a wider white line drawn underneath so the coloured route is readable over any map background.

Q12. Why do GeoJSON layers have a `key`?
react-leaflet's GeoJSON ignores changes to its data, so we key it by the request path; a new response creates a new layer.

BACKEND

Q13. Why a separate Python backend?
The geometry, astronomy and graph libraries we need (Shapely, pvlib, OSMnx, NetworkX) are Python. The frontend only sends settings and draws results.

Q14. What does FastAPI validate for you?
Types and ranges of every query parameter (e.g. `sun_avoidance` 0–100, `w_rain` 0–50, valid date/time), answering 422 automatically. We add checks for the date range and the campus boundary.

Q15. Why is moving the sun-avoidance slider so fast?
The whole set of route options is cached per trip, time and rain weight; the slider only re-runs `pick()` on the cached list. A cached request takes about 15 ms on the server.

Q16. How does the backend know a pin is on campus?
It converts the pin to metres and tests it against the OSM campus polygon with Shapely, then snaps it to the nearest graph node, however far away it is. The frontend does the same polygon check first (ray casting), but the backend never trusts the client.

Q17. What happens if a pin is far from any path?
It snaps to the nearest walkway node, however far away, and the map draws a dotted line from the pin to the route. Time and distance count only the walkway part. Off-campus pins are refused.

Q18. Does the app need the internet to compute routes?
Only for weather and map tiles. The graph, buildings and trees are committed cache files loaded at start-up; without weather it falls back to a clear sky.

GRAPHS AND ALGORITHMS

Q19. What are the vertices and edges?
Vertices are walkway intersections/endpoints (1,804); edges are walkway segments in each direction (5,172) with length and geometry, from OpenStreetMap.

Q20. Dijkstra or A*?
A*, which is Dijkstra plus a lower-bound estimate of the remaining cost. Our estimate is straight-line distance ÷ 1.4 m/s × 0.99. It never overestimates, so A* returns the same optimal cost as Dijkstra (checked during development) while settling about half as many nodes (876 vs 1,703 on the demo trip).

Q21. Why is your heuristic admissible?
No path is shorter than the straight line, and every edge costs at least its walking time because the rain term is never negative.

Q22. Why not just add sun to the cost with a weight?
A weighted sum can only find routes on the convex hull of the time/sun trade-off, so the route jumps and skips good compromises. We compute the full Pareto set and let the slider choose among all of them.

Q23. What is a Pareto-optimal route?
One that no other route beats on both time and sun at once. Every option in our list is slower but shadier than the one before.

Q24. What does 50 % sun avoidance mean exactly?
Take the quickest route that removes at least half of the sun that is avoidable on this trip (the difference between the fastest and the shadiest option).

Q25. What's the complexity?
A* with a binary heap is O(E log V) in the worst case. The Pareto search can hold several labels per node, so it is bounded by limiting options to 50 % extra cost and requiring each to cut sun by 2 %; in practice the first request for a trip takes about 0.25 s and later ones are cached.

MATHEMATICS

Q26. How do you compute a shadow?
L = h / tan(θ): a roof at height h casts its shadow L metres away, opposite the sun: offset (−L sin α, −L cos α). The building's shadow is its footprint swept along that offset (convex hull for convex buildings, per-wall parallelograms for concave ones).

Q27. What is a sun-second?
One second spent in full-strength direct sun. Half-strength sun for two seconds is also one sun-second. Per edge: walking time × average intensity × unshaded fraction.

Q28. What does "Sun 27 %" mean on the card?
The route gets 27 % of the direct sun it would get if nothing cast a shadow on it. The backend sends 27.x, already a percentage.

Q29. Why the trapezoid rule?
Sun intensity changes over a walk, so exposure is an integral over time. The trapezoid rule averages entry and exit intensity per edge; edges take seconds, so it is very accurate.

Q30. Degrees or radians?
The API and UI use degrees; the code converts with `math.radians` before sin/tan.

Q31. Why sample points instead of exact line–shadow intersection?
Speed. The 121,632 sample points never move, so they are indexed once in an STRtree, and each 15-minute shadow is one spatial query. Intersecting thousands of shadow polygons with every walkway exactly would be much slower, for almost no gain in accuracy.

Q32. How accurate is the 1.5 m sampling?
During development a test compared it with exact line/polygon overlap over the whole campus at three times of day; the length-weighted difference was under 0.5 percentage points.

WEATHER AND RAIN

Q33. Where does the weather come from and how often?
Open-Meteo, hourly direct radiation, cloud cover and precipitation, fetched by the backend and cached 30 minutes per date (60 s after a failure).

Q34. Do clouds change the route?
Yes, through direct radiation: under heavy cloud the direct beam is weak, so there is little sun to avoid. The cloud-cover percentage itself is only displayed.

Q35. Is rain routing real?
Yes. With "Avoid rain" on, the Detour cost becomes time + 10 × rain-seconds, where rain-seconds count rain intensity on unsheltered walkway (buildings and OSM covered/indoor tags give shelter). If it isn't raining, it changes nothing.

Q36. What if the weather API is down?
The backend falls back to a clear, dry sky (sun intensity = sin of elevation) and the panel says "Weather unavailable, assuming clear sky".

DESIGN, TESTING, LIMITATIONS

Q37. Why show the fastest route too?

So the user sees the trade-off: "+48 sec vs fastest" and "Sun 89 % → 71 %". Detour is green and drawn on top; Fastest is a red dotted reference.

Q38. How do you know the router is correct?

During development, automated tests checked that the fastest route matches NetworkX's shortest path on random campus pairs, that A* matches Dijkstra, that the Pareto options are strictly slower and shadier and include every weighted-sum route, and that a toy graph with a known answer takes the shade detour. All 75 tests passed on the final code.

Q39. Do you have automated tests?

We wrote 75: 15 frontend (queries, validation, time zones, point-in-polygon) and 60 backend (router, API, shadows, weather, data), and all passed on the final code. They are not kept in the final repository; lint and the type-checked production build still run.

Q40. What's the biggest limitation?

We model direct-sun exposure, not full thermal comfort: no air temperature, humidity or wind, uniform trees, maximum building heights, and one weather point for the campus.

Q41. What would you build next?

A comfort score with temperature and humidity, real tree sizes, door opening hours for indoor routes, live GPS navigation, and other campuses (the pipeline only needs a boundary, the OSM walk network and building heights).

Q42. Is Detour really "heat-aware"?

It is direct-sun-aware: it measures how many seconds of direct sun each route gets, from real shadows and live direct radiation. Air temperature and humidity are not used; a comfort score combining them would be a natural next step.

16 Pitches

16.1 The 30-second explanation

Detour is a walking map for York's Keele Campus that keeps you out of the sun. You drop a start and an end pin, pick how much sun you want to avoid, and Detour compares the fastest route with a shadier one, telling you exactly how much extra time it costs. Behind it, we compute real building and tree shadows from the sun's position, combine them with live weather, and search every trade-off between walking time and sun exposure across the campus walkway graph.

16.2 The 90-second technical explanation

The frontend is Next.js and React with a Leaflet map. React state holds the date, time, pins and sliders; every change becomes a URL, which a custom hook debounces for 150 ms, fetches with cancellation, and validates before drawing the GeoJSON route.

The backend is FastAPI in Python. The campus is a graph of 1,804 walkway intersections and 5,172 directed edges from OpenStreetMap, projected into metres. We get the sun's elevation and azimuth from pvlib and cast shadows from 737 City of Toronto buildings and 1,181 trees with $L = h / \tan \theta$, sweeping each footprint away from the sun.

We sample every walkway every 1.5 m to get its shaded fraction, then integrate sun exposure over the walk in sun-seconds, using live direct radiation from Open-Meteo so clouds count. Instead of a single weighted cost, we run a bicriteria A* search that finds the Pareto set of routes trading time for shade. The slider picks the quickest route that removes the chosen share of the avoidable sun, and optional rain avoidance keeps you under roofs. During development, automated tests confirmed that our A* matches Dijkstra and NetworkX.

16.3 The 3-minute team presentation

FRONTEND PERSON: THE PROBLEM AND THE APP 0:00–0:45

On a hot day, the fastest walk across campus is often in full sun, while a route one minute longer is in shade. Detour shows you both. *[Demo: place two pins.]* Green is Detour, red dotted is the fastest route. The panel says how much time and sun each takes. When I move the sun-avoidance slider, the green route changes; when I move the time, everything updates, because the app is built in React and every input is state. Changes are debounced and old requests are cancelled, so it stays responsive. Turning on Show shadows draws the actual building and tree shadows for this moment.

GRAPH PERSON: THE NETWORK AND THE SEARCH 0:45–1:30

The campus is a graph: 1,804 intersections and 5,172 directed walkway edges from OpenStreetMap, in metres. The fastest route is A*: Dijkstra guided by a straight-line lower bound, which gives the same answer while exploring about half the nodes. But for shade, a single weighted cost only finds a few routes. So we search for the Pareto set: every route where you can't get less sun without walking longer. On our demo trip that's 9 routes. The slider means "avoid this share of the avoidable sun", and we take the quickest route that does it.

MATH PERSON: SUN, SHADOWS AND EXPOSURE 1:30–2:15

We compute the sun's elevation θ and azimuth α for every minute of the day. A building of height h casts a shadow L = h / tan θ long, pointing away from the sun, so at noon in June a 20 m building casts about 7 m of shadow, and in December about 48 m. We sweep each footprint along that vector. Trees are crown disks from 2 to 9 m up. Each walkway is sampled every 1.5 m to get its shaded fraction, and exposure is an integral: sun-seconds equal walking time times sun intensity times the unshaded fraction, summed edge by edge at the time you actually reach it.

BACKEND PERSON: WEATHER, ENGINEERING, HONESTY 2:15–3:00

Sun intensity comes from live Open-Meteo direct radiation, because shade only blocks the direct beam; on a cloudy day there is little to avoid and Detour says so. With Avoid rain on, we also count rain-seconds on unsheltered walkways and stay under roofs. It's a FastAPI backend with caching, so slider changes answer in milliseconds, and during development we checked that A* matches Dijkstra. Limits: we model direct sun, not air temperature, and trees are a standard size. Next we'd add a comfort score and live navigation. Thank you.

17 If you only remember 10 things

1. **Frontend draws, backend thinks.** Next.js/React/Leaflet in the browser; FastAPI/Python does all routing, sun, shadow and weather maths and returns JSON + GeoJSON.
2. **The campus is a graph** G = (V, E): 1,804 nodes, 5,172 directed walkway edges from OpenStreetMap, in metres (UTM 17N). Walking speed 1.4 m/s, so $\tau = d / 1.4$.
3. **A* = Dijkstra + straight-line lower bound** (0.99 × distance ÷ 1.4). Same optimal answer, about half the nodes (876 vs 1,703).
4. **The Detour route comes from a Pareto set**, not a single weight: every route that trades extra time for less sun (max 50 % extra cost, each step ≥ 2 % less sun). The slider picks the quickest that removes the chosen share of avoidable sun: target = $S_{fast} - p\,(S_{fast} - S_{shadiest})$.
5. **Shadow length L = h / tan θ**, direction (−L sin α, −L cos α), away from the sun. Nothing below 3°, capped at 300 m. Buildings are swept footprints; trees are 3 m crowns from 2 to 9 m.
6. **Sun-seconds**: $S_e = \tau \times$ average intensity × (1 − shade fraction). Shade fraction comes from sample points every 1.5 m and the nearest 15-minute shadow.
7. **Intensity = direct radiation / 1000 W/m²** from Open-Meteo (clear-sky fallback sin θ). Clouds matter through direct radiation; cloud % is display only. Weather is cached 30 min.
8. **Units:** sun avoidance 0–100 in UI and URL, ÷ 100 in the backend; sun % is already a percentage; cloud cover is 0–1. Angles in degrees, converted to radians for trig. Times are Toronto local.
9. **Coordinates:** Leaflet [lat, lon], GeoJSON [lon, lat], backend (x, y) metres.
10. **Reliability:** 150 ms debounce, AbortController, stale routes dimmed, Retry, validated responses; backend caches make slider moves ~15 ms. Lint and build clean; 75 automated tests passed during development.

AND ONE HONEST SENTENCE

"Detour models direct-sun exposure from real shadows and live weather; it does not yet model air temperature, humidity or individual tree sizes."

18 Glossary

Term	Meaning
A*	Dijkstra's algorithm guided by a guess of the remaining cost, so it explores fewer nodes.
Admissible heuristic	A guess of the remaining cost that never overestimates it, so A* still finds the best route.
Azimuth (α)	Compass direction of the sun, in degrees clockwise from north.
Bicriteria search	A search that optimises two things at once (here cost and sun) and keeps every trade-off.
Casing	A wider white line drawn under a route so the coloured line stands out.
CORS	Browser rule for which websites may call an API; the backend allows only the Detour site and local development.
Debounce	Wait until input stops changing (150 ms) before acting, so dragging a slider sends one request.
Dijkstra's algorithm	Finds shortest paths by always expanding the cheapest unsettled node.
Direct radiation	Sunlight arriving straight from the sun (W/m^2); the only part shade can block.
Edge	A walkway segment between two nodes, with a length and a shape.
Elevation (θ)	Height of the sun above the horizon, in degrees.
Endpoint	A URL the backend answers, e.g. /route.
GeoJSON	Standard JSON format for map shapes; coordinates are [longitude, latitude].
Graph G = (V, E)	A set of nodes V joined by edges E; the campus walkways.
Label	One partial route in the bicriteria search: its cost, sun and arrival time at a node.
Node (vertex)	A point where walkways meet or end.
Pareto set	All routes that no other route beats on both time and sun.
Projection (UTM 17N)	Turning latitude/longitude into flat x/y metres so lengths and shadows are in metres.
Rain-second	One second out in moderate rain (or more) with no roof.
Shade fraction f	Share of an edge's 1.5 m sample points that are in shadow.
Shelter fraction g	Share of an edge under a roof (inside a building, or a covered/indoor walkway).
SSR	Server-side rendering: HTML made on the server; the map is excluded because Leaflet needs a browser.
Stale	A shown answer that belongs to older settings; it is dimmed until the new one arrives.
STRtree	A spatial index (Shapely) for fast "which shapes are near this one?" queries.
Sun-second	One second in full-strength direct sun; half-strength sun for 2 s is also one sun-second.
Time slice	A 15-minute window; shadows are computed once per slice.
Trapezoid rule	Approximating an integral by averaging the start and end values times the duration.